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Dummy's Guide to Not Getting Scammed

Practical checks for trucking companies, dispatchers, admins, and load-booking teams

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Dummy’s Guide to Not Getting Scammed

Practical checks for trucking companies and everyone acting for the carrier

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Educational material for U.S. freight operations. Recommended procedures are identified separately from regulations and agency guidance. This book is not individual legal, insurance, financial, or technical advice. Obtain qualified assistance for the facts of an actual dispute or incident.

Practice cases are fictional. The two author-supplied inquiries are limited teaching examples, not findings against named companies or people. No loss or investigation outcome is invented.

Cover and chapter photographs were generated for this edition. They depict illustrative scenes and fictional people, not the actual inquiries or incidents. Text, source checks, and production used AI assistance with editorial review.

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Before you book the next load

You don't have to know every scam ever invented. You do need a way to decide when a person has earned the right to receive your paperwork, give your driver instructions, or change where your money goes.

That's what this book is for.

A carrier can lose money before a truck leaves the yard. Someone gets a copy of a carrier packet, takes over an email account, changes a payment instruction, or sends a driver to the wrong place. The first message may be polite. The rate may be reasonable. The company named in the signature may be real.

The question is whether the person speaking for that company is authorized to do what they're asking you to do. Then you have to connect that person to this particular shipment. Those are separate checks.

This book is for the owner answering the phone, the dispatcher finding the next load, the administrator handling setup, the person sending invoices, and the driver standing at the shipping window. If you act for a carrier, your decision can commit that carrier's truck, records, money, or reputation.

The word “Dummy's” in the title isn't a judgment about you. Freight has a language, a pace, and a pile of paperwork that can make a new person feel behind before they start. Experienced people get rushed too. Asking a basic question is part of running the business.

A working rule

Before an action is difficult to undo, establish who is asking, what authority they have, and exactly what they want changed. Keep a record of how you checked. If the facts don't match, pause that action and bring in the person responsible for the decision.

You don't need to accuse anyone to pause. “Our verification isn't complete” is a sufficient explanation. A delay may cost you a load. An unverified release can cost you much more, and the person answering a busy phone shouldn't have to make that trade alone.

The procedures in this book are recommended company practices unless a section specifically identifies a law or agency instruction. They are written for ordinary U.S. property transportation. Specialized commodities, cross-border movements, hazardous materials, household goods, and individual contracts can add requirements. Use qualified advice for an actual legal dispute or coverage decision.

How to use the book

Read Chapters 1 through 4 before you approve a new trading relationship. Chapters 5 through 7 cover the messages, documents, and money requests that arrive while a load is being arranged. Chapters 8 and 9 belong in driver training. Chapter 10 belongs with whoever sends invoices or changes payment records. Chapter 11 is the section to open when something has already happened. Chapter 12 turns individual habits into a company process.

Each chapter includes a practice decision and an explanation. Try the decision before reading the answer. Several situations have an unresolved fact on purpose. In real work, “I can't establish that yet” is sometimes the correct answer.

The worksheets near the back can be copied for internal training and operations. Use a fresh record for each load or incident. Keep confidential details in your controlled company system; a shared training copy should contain invented information only.

The examples marked “Practice case” are fictional teaching scenarios. Their companies, amounts, and outcomes are invented. Chapter 1 contains two author-supplied inquiries, identified separately and limited to what the supplied messages establish. The generated photographs illustrate ordinary work. They do not depict the people, companies, or events in those inquiries.

Five decisions worth slowing down for

• Sending company, driver, insurance, tax, or banking documents to a new recipient.

• Signing in through a link or allowing a new application to access an account.

• Accepting a shipment before the contracting parties and actual carrier are clear.

• Releasing freight or changing a pickup, delivery, driver, or equipment instruction.

• Sending money, changing a bank account, or accepting a new assignment of payment.

Make those decisions visible. “I assumed someone else checked” is a process problem that a small company can fix today.

What the freight-fraud numbers actually tell you

Numbers can explain why a procedure deserves time. They can't tell you whether today's caller is legitimate. The figures below describe different populations, periods, and categories. Don't add them together or put them on a single growth chart.

TIA: a member survey and a reporting system

The Transportation Intermediaries Association's April 2025 report used 59 member responses collected January 2–February 6, 2025. It reports that 96% devoted time each quarter to managing fraud-related incidents. That does not mean they spent one-quarter of their working time on fraud. This is a small industry-member survey, not a census. Separately, TIA Watchdog received 1,611 reports from September 1, 2024, through February 28, 2025—65% more than the preceding eight-month period. Those are reports, not adjudicated crimes, and the periods have different lengths. TIA also carries a broad annual-loss estimate attributed to NICB, not a loss total measured by these respondents. [S1]

ATRI: a modeled cost range

The American Transportation Research Institute's October 2025 study estimates annual truck cargo-theft costs of roughly $1.8–$6.6 billion. Its 2023 direct-loss estimates are about $457–$937 million; the larger totals add indirect costs using multipliers and extrapolate survey findings to a truck population. The $6.6 billion figure is the upper end, not a verified inventory of stolen cargo. Tables 10–12 explain the assumptions. The study reports 43.2% of surveyed carriers experienced theft in 2023; 65.3% had experienced it in 2023 or earlier. Those are different time windows. [S2]

A percentage needs its category

The American Trucking Associations cites CargoNet for a 1,500% increase in strategic cargo theft since 2021. Strategic theft generally involves deception used to obtain freight, rather than simply stealing an unattended trailer. This attributed claim should not be relabeled “all freight fraud increased 1,500%,” nor treated as a fresh measurement through this book's publication date. [S3]

You may encounter much larger estimates elsewhere. Before repeating one, ask: Is this theft, attempted fraud, reported incidents, direct cargo value, or total economic cost? Is it a survey, a database count, or an extrapolation? Which years are being compared? If the source doesn't answer those questions, the number isn't ready for your training slide.

Use the evidence without overstating it

These sources support taking the problem seriously. They do not supply a universal probability that a particular load is fraudulent. A carrier's exposure depends on its freight, customers, lanes, systems, staffing, and operating choices. Your own records should track attempted incidents separately from confirmed losses and ordinary service disputes.

For a useful monthly review, count new counterparties checked, changes independently confirmed, holds resolved, attempted scams reported, and losses actually documented. Give each figure a definition. If one dispatcher logs every suspicious email and another logs only money lost, a comparison between them won't tell you much.

The most useful number in a specific load file may be much smaller: the time the known customer confirmed the actual delivery address, or the reference number assigned to a bank's fraud report. Those details can explain what happened and what still needs attention.

1
The inquiry that sounds like a customer



A promising inquiry is the beginning of a check, not the end of one.

An email offers steady work. The routes are specific. The sender asks about capacity and transit time. Nothing in the opening message tells you to wire money or hand over a password. It's easy to start calculating what those loads could mean for the week.

Keep that commercial interest. Just don't let it become trust before you've checked the sender. Your task in this chapter is to separate a plausible business opportunity from an authenticated business relationship.

Two inquiries supplied by the author

In the first inquiry, a sender claimed to represent Edgewell Personal Care and used an address ending in edgewellusa.com. The message described approximately 50 shipments from Kalispell, Montana, to Riviera Beach, Florida, and asked about price, capacity, transit time, and additional charges.

The second claimed to represent Inteva Products LLC and used intevaproductsllc.com. It described seven or eight weekly auto-parts loads from Glen Allen, Virginia, to Portland, Oregon. It included a headquarters address at 1401 Crooks Road, Suite 100, Troy, Michigan 48084.

The author supplied these as suspected impersonation attempts. The supplied opening inquiries do not establish who controlled the accounts, whether the named individuals sent them, what a later attachment contained, or whether any loss occurred. This book makes no allegation that Edgewell, Inteva, or the people named in the inquiries committed fraud. Their names could themselves have been used without authorization.

What can be compared

At the source check for this edition, Edgewell's published contact information used edgewell.com. Inteva's published contact information used intevaproducts.com. The Troy address in the second inquiry matched Inteva's published headquarters address. [S4, S5]

That gives us a specific mismatch to resolve: the inquiry domains differ from the companies' published contact domains. An added “usa” or “llc” can make a domain look familiar while still being a different address. It does not, by itself, establish criminal intent. Companies can operate more than one domain. The next step is independent confirmation from the real organization, obtained through a channel you select yourself.

The matching street address doesn't answer the email question. A real address is public information. So are executive names, product lines, logos, and photographs of buildings. A sender can copy accurate facts into an unauthorized message.

Don't visit the questioned domains just to see whether they look professional. Their appearance cannot authenticate the sender, and opening an unfamiliar site adds an unnecessary interaction. Record the spelling as text and use independently located corporate information for the callback.

Before you send the packet

Start a prospect record with the original message, its received date, the claimed company, the complete sender address, and the proposed lane. Preserve the original email if you have it. A screenshot is useful for reading, but it doesn't preserve all of an email's routing information.

Find the company's public contact route independently. Ask to speak with the transportation or procurement function. You aren't asking the receptionist to guarantee a stranger. You're asking whether the organization can confirm a specific request and the person or team authorized to handle it.

Try this wording: “We received a freight inquiry using your company's name. Before we exchange setup documents, can your transportation team confirm whether the request and this email domain belong to you?” Give enough information to identify the inquiry without sending your tax form, bank details, driver identification, or a complete carrier packet.

If you reach the appropriate department, ask about this shipment opportunity, not just the employee's existence. An employee can be real while a message bearing that employee's name is unauthorized. A confirmed corporate email can also be compromised. The load still needs to make operational sense.

If nobody can confirm the request, leave it unresolved. Don't upgrade “we couldn't reach anyone” into “verified.” You can tell the sender that your company cannot proceed until its customer verification is complete. You don't owe an unknown sender the private details of your checking process.

What not to conclude from the lane

A manufacturing company can use a third-party warehouse far from its headquarters. An unfamiliar origin city isn't proof that an inquiry is fake. A long lane, recurring volume, or detailed commodity description isn't proof that it's genuine either.

Ask operational questions after you establish a legitimate contact: Who tenders the shipment? Which facility releases it? What equipment is required? Who pays the carrier? Which party can authorize a change? Those answers should connect to the written agreement and to the people your driver will encounter.

The author's article, “How to Spot a Fake Shipper Scam,” is useful background for this checking habit. Its broader observations should not be confused with independently established findings about these two messages. The teaching point here is the mismatch and the unresolved sender authority. [S6]

Practice case: the correct address

A fictional prospect sends a polished inquiry with a real company's headquarters address. The email uses a domain with one extra word. Your dispatcher finds the company in a business directory and says, “They exist. Send the setup form.”

Write down three things that have been established and three that have not. Then choose the next action: send the full packet, accuse the sender, or contact the organization independently.

The company exists, its published address can be checked, and a message makes a claim about freight. The sender's authority, the

ownership or authorization of that email domain, and the actual shipment request remain unconfirmed. Make the independent contact. Neither sending sensitive documents nor making a public accusation is justified by the facts so far.

Keep this distinction

A matching fact supports one part of a story. It doesn't authenticate the whole story. Your prospect record should say what was checked, who confirmed it, and what remains open. That makes the next person's decision easier and keeps enthusiasm from becoming an undocumented approval.

Freight Broker Complaint: read about cyber-enabled cargo theft and how impersonation can enter a transaction.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: use the service's current information when considering how your team reviews suspicious inquiries; verify available features before relying on them.
lfsshield.com

2
Make the callback yours



Select the contact route independently before you ask for confirmation.

Calling someone back feels like verification. It only helps if you know whose number you're calling. A number in the questionable email, a reply from the same thread, and a new number supplied by the caller all lead back to the same unverified source.

This chapter teaches a callback that creates a separate route to the organization. The goal is to establish the authority behind the instruction, not simply hear a reassuring voice.

Build a contact record before the emergency

For an established customer, keep approved contacts in a company-controlled record. Include the source of each number, who confirmed it, the date, and the decisions that person may authorize. A shipping clerk may confirm an appointment without having authority to change the contracting customer or bank account.

Don't let a new email silently overwrite that record. A contact change is itself a change to verify. Keep the old entry and the evidence supporting the replacement. Otherwise an intruder can change the number first and pass your callback check later.

For a new broker or carrier, begin with the appropriate official FMCSA records and independently established company information. For a shipper, use its independently located corporate channels. A search advertisement isn't an official record merely because it appears first. Type known government addresses or use bookmarks your company has checked. [S7, S8]

No directory is a guarantee. A record may be old, and a legitimate account can be compromised. Use the callback together with the actual transaction details. If two sources disagree, document the disagreement instead of choosing whichever number gets a fast answer.

Ask a question that can be answered

“Are you legitimate?” doesn't give you much. Ask a specific question: “Can your transportation team confirm that your company tendered load 4821 to our carrier for pickup tomorrow, and that this person may issue the rate confirmation?”

Use a reference number when you have one, but don't assume possession of it proves authorization. Load details can leak. Ask the independently reached contact to confirm the contracting

entity, scheduled facilities, and approved communication route. Record the answers in your file.

A useful callback note reads: “October 28, 10:15 a.m. Eastern. Called number from approved customer record created September 3. Reached shipping supervisor through main switchboard. Supervisor confirmed pickup appointment and tendering broker; referred payment terms to accounts payable. Payment terms still pending.” That note shows the limits of the call.

“Spoke to someone, all good” doesn't.

Use ordinary language

You can say, “We confirm new load contacts before sending company paperwork. Can you connect me with the person responsible for this shipment?” You don't need to sound like an investigator. Be clear about the business reason for the call.

If the person won't answer, can't find the load, or sends you back to the suspicious number, the check remains incomplete. A receptionist's inability to locate a reference doesn't prove fraud. It also doesn't approve dispatch. Escalate through your company process and keep the affected action on hold.

If a sender objects to the delay, repeat the boundary: “We can continue once our authorized contact confirms the request.” Avoid negotiating away the check because the sender becomes friendly, angry, or generous. Those reactions don't supply the missing evidence.

After-hours work needs an after-hours plan

A carrier that books at night needs a way to verify at night. Establish emergency numbers during ordinary onboarding, including who may authorize a delivery change. Test those numbers periodically through a routine operational call. Don't wait until a loaded truck is outside a closed warehouse.

When an authorized contact is unavailable, the next step belongs to your designated manager. The manager should see the unresolved fact and the available evidence. A manager's decision to accept commercial risk should never be relabeled “independently verified” if the check wasn't completed.

For a high-consequence change such as a new bank account or delivery location, set a firm company rule that the action waits for the required confirmation. Staff need to know that losing a proposed load is preferable to secretly bypassing that rule. Build reasonable verification time into service expectations with customers.

Keep the driver out of the middle

The driver shouldn't have to choose between two strangers who both sound official. Dispatch should provide one approved escalation route and a clear instruction to stop the affected action safely when instructions conflict. A driver can report the conflict; the office should establish the authority.

Don't ask a driver to research corporate records while driving. The driver parks safely before calling or reviewing messages. If the location is unsafe, immediate personal safety and emergency assistance come first. Verification is an office process, not a reason to remain in danger.

Practice case: a familiar voice

In a fictional scenario, a caller says they are the customer's usual shipping manager. You recognize the voice. They ask you to send the loaded truck to a different warehouse and provide a new phone number because “the old line is down.”

What should happen before the driver follows the new route? Write the specific source you would use for the callback and the facts you would confirm.

Use the existing approved contact route or another independently established corporate route. Confirm the change with someone authorized to issue it, including the complete address, receiving party, appointment, and written instruction. A familiar voice and a plausible outage don't establish that authority. Voice familiarity can be mistaken, and the caller is trying to choose the verification channel.

The driver should receive a clear hold instruction for the changed destination while dispatch resolves it. This does not authorize abandoning freight or creating a roadside hazard. Coordinate a safe operating plan through the carrier's responsible manager.

Put it into use today

Choose one current customer and inspect its contact record. Can a second employee tell where the number came from, who may authorize changes, and when it was last checked? Repair that one record. Then use the same method for the next customer instead of building a list nobody trusts.

Freight Broker Complaint: its complaint guide shows the value of a specific, dated record when an issue must be explained.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: consider how inquiry reviews fit with your independently maintained contact list; a software result does not replace the callback.
lfsshield.com

3
Know who is hiring the truck



The names on the documents should explain the transaction, not obscure it.

Before a truck moves, you should be able to explain the load in a few sentences. Who owns or tenders the freight? Who arranged transportation? Which carrier accepted it? Who owes the carrier? Who may change the instructions?

If those answers keep changing, more paperwork won't necessarily make the load clearer. This chapter helps you connect the parties and recognize when a dispatch arrangement needs closer review.

Four roles that can be confused

A shipper tenders freight. A broker arranges transportation. A motor carrier undertakes the transportation. A dispatcher may perform administrative or arranging work for a carrier, but the title “dispatcher” does not decide the legal character of the work.

One business can hold more than one role, and a shipment can involve several legitimate businesses. Record the role being performed in this transaction. An MC number on a signature doesn't tell you whether that entity is acting as the carrier, broker, or an unauthorized intermediary on this load.

The first sentence of 49 CFR 371.2(a) states: “Broker means a person who, for compensation, arranges, or offers to arrange, the transportation of property by an authorized motor carrier.” [S9]

Read the rest of the section too. It includes an exception for motor carriers and their employees or bona fide agents arranging transportation the carrier is authorized to transport and has accepted and legally bound itself to transport. The bona fide agent definition concerns an ongoing relationship under the carrier's direction and the absence of discretion to allocate traffic between that carrier and others. A short label on a contract doesn't settle those facts.

What a dispatch service actually does matters

FMCSA's June 2023 final guidance discusses broker and bona fide agent status, including dispatch services. Relevant facts include the agreements, who pays the service, whether it solicits shippers, whether it accepts freight before identifying a carrier, and whether it allocates traffic among carriers. Working with multiple carriers is not, by itself, the whole legal test. [S10]

For your own dispatch relationship, write down the scope of authority. Can the dispatcher sign rate confirmations? Submit setup forms? Communicate with shippers? Receive money? Hire another carrier? Access the load board? A carrier owner should know these answers before handing over account access.

Have qualified counsel review an arrangement when the actual activities approach brokerage. Don't assume that calling someone an independent dispatcher removes registration obligations. Don't

ask a new administrator to resolve that question by guessing from a website.

Follow the load, not just the logo

Create a simple party map in the file: tendering customer, arranging broker if any, actual operating carrier, dispatch representative, pickup facility, receiver, and payor. Use legal names and identifiers where applicable. Write “unknown” where the answer is unknown.

Compare the rate confirmation with the agreement, the appointment, and the instructions provided to the driver. If the booking party says the carrier must present itself under another company's name, stop and escalate. Do not coach the driver to lie at the shipping window. FMCSA specifically identifies that request as a reason to stop the transaction. [S7]

A trade name, leased equipment arrangement, or other legitimate operating relationship may explain a difference. The explanation must be supported and understood by the responsible parties. A verbal “everybody does it” is not a substitute for resolving who is actually authorized to carry the load.

Double brokering and co-brokering

People use “double brokering” loosely. It often describes an unauthorized or concealed re-tendering of freight, sometimes involving impersonation or nonpayment. Co-brokering can describe a disclosed arrangement between properly authorized brokers. The important facts are authority, consent, disclosure, and contractual obligations—not merely the number of businesses involved.

Don't teach staff that any second broker proves a crime. Teach them to ask why that broker is involved and whether the parties with authority approved the arrangement. Similarly, don't accept

“co-brokering” as a magic explanation for an undisclosed carrier substitution.

If you're the operating carrier, obtain clear written terms identifying who contracted with you and who will pay you. If a party changes after acceptance, treat that as a change requiring review. Avoid signing a replacement document just because someone says accounting needs it. The replacement may alter the contracting party or payment responsibility.

Practice case: a changed name at the gate

A fictional dispatcher books a load with Broker A for Carrier B. Thirty minutes before pickup, a text says, “Tell the guard you're Carrier C. That's the name in their system. We'll fix the paperwork after loading.” The rate confirmation still names Carrier B.

Your driver asks whether to use the new name. What is your instruction, and who must resolve the discrepancy?

The driver should not misrepresent the carrier. Pause pickup and have the carrier's responsible manager contact the verified broker and shipping facility through established channels. Establish the authorized operating carrier and obtain corrected instructions before release. If the parties cannot reconcile the names, do not proceed on the promise of later paperwork.

The text is evidence of an instruction, not evidence that Carrier C authorized anything. Preserve it without publishing accusations about that company. Its identity may also be misused.

A useful office exercise

Take a completed load and draw its party map without asking the dispatcher who booked it. Can you identify the contracting party, operating carrier, payor, and authorized change contact from the records alone? If not, repair the onboarding fields for future loads. Don't alter historical documents to make the old file appear complete; add a dated explanation of what you learned.

The point is accountability. When everyone knows which decision belongs to which party, a stranger has fewer opportunities to insert a new instruction between them.

Freight Broker Complaint: compare its discussion of double brokering and co-brokering with the official definitions linked in this chapter.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: use a clearly documented party map when seeking help reviewing a freight transaction.
lfsshield.com

4
A real MC number can be borrowed



Match the person, the company record, and the actual operation.

A real company's identity is useful to someone pretending to be that company. The legal name may be correct. The MC number may be active. The insurance certificate may look familiar. Those facts still don't tell you whether the person sending the packet represents that carrier.

This chapter is about the gap between a valid business record and an authorized person. It also explains why your own carrier information deserves regular attention.

Separate identity from eligibility

Identity asks whether you're dealing with the organization you think you're dealing with. Eligibility asks whether that organization has the authority and other requirements needed for the work. A business can pass one check and fail the other.

Use FMCSA's official resources for the questions those resources answer. SAFER provides company snapshot information. Follow FMCSA's current registration and licensing resources for authority and insurance filings. A USDOT number alone is not proof of active interstate for-hire operating authority for the proposed service. [S8, S11]

Check the legal name, DBA if applicable, USDOT and MC identifiers, operating status, and relevant authority. Record the date because status can change. Avoid treating a screenshot supplied by the booking party as a current official lookup. Read the live record through a trusted route.

Then establish the representative's connection to the business. Use the independent contact process from Chapter 2. If the email, phone, address, or proposed payee differs from the record, write down the difference and resolve it. A small company using a general email provider isn't automatically fraudulent. A polished company domain isn't automatically safe.

Read changes in context

A recent address or phone change deserves explanation, especially when it arrives with a new dispatcher, new payment destination, and urgent load request. One change may be ordinary. Several changes at once can leave you with no stable contact route.

Don't build a rule that rejects every new carrier or every changed record. New businesses need to operate too. Build a rule that asks for enough independent evidence to establish the relationship and

the load. Your standard should be consistent and related to the decision being made.

An old authority date doesn't establish who controls today's email account. A long relationship doesn't make a sudden payment change self-authenticating. Repeat the relevant checks when a material detail changes, even if the company was approved years ago.

Keep your identity from being easy to reuse

Decide who may access the carrier's registration account, load boards, email administration, insurance records, and document library. Use individual accounts where the service supports them. Shared passwords make it harder to revoke access and harder to determine who made a change.

When a dispatcher or employee leaves, remove the access they no longer need. Review forwarding rules, recovery contacts, delegated mail access, and connected applications with your administrator. Changing a single password may leave other forms of access in place.

Maintain a current carrier packet in a controlled location. If staff keep sending old copies from personal devices, a wrong number or obsolete bank instruction can circulate long after you corrected it. Give the current version a date and retire prior versions from routine use while retaining required records.

A visible recipient and purpose note on a shared document can help track distribution, where appropriate and accepted. It won't stop copying or alteration. Don't obscure official information, signatures, or required certificate fields with a watermark. Confirm the recipient and transfer method first.

When someone says your MC is on their load

Treat an unexpected call about a load your carrier didn't accept as a lead worth checking. Get the caller's name, company, independently verifiable contact information, load reference, and the documents they are willing to provide through an approved channel. Don't send them your entire packet to prove who you are.

Check internally before drawing conclusions. A dispatcher may have booked it, or the caller may have the wrong number. If the load is unauthorized, preserve the documents and notify the involved legitimate parties through independent routes. Contact the relevant platform and FMCSA through their official channels, and follow the reporting steps in Chapter 11.

Correct false information through the proper account process. Do not create another company profile as a quick workaround. You want a clear record of the real carrier and the disputed activity, not two competing identities that confuse customers further.

Practice case: the complete packet

A fictional booking contact sends a carrier packet containing an active MC number, a W-9, an insurance certificate, and a logo. The phone number in the email differs from the number in your independently obtained company record. The sender says the listed number belongs to “the old office.”

What does the packet establish? What is still missing? What should you avoid doing while the difference is unresolved?

The packet establishes what the sender is claiming. Its documents may contain verifiable information, but possession of copies does not establish permission to represent the carrier. The changed contact route needs independent confirmation. Avoid approving the relationship, releasing sensitive load details beyond what is

necessary, or accepting a replacement payee until the relevant checks are complete.

Call the established route or another independently located corporate contact. If you cannot resolve the identity, keep the record pending. A deadline doesn't turn a copied packet into authorization.

A weekly habit for the carrier owner

Assign someone to check the carrier's own public contact information and review unexpected account notices. Keep a dated record of changes your company actually requested. Establish how staff report a suspected unauthorized change without replying to the suspicious notice.

Also ask your regular customers how they handle carrier substitutions and new contact requests. If they accept a new phone number without checking with you, your own careful process covers only half the relationship. A short onboarding conversation can clarify who is allowed to change what before an urgent shipment exposes the gap.

Freight Broker Complaint: review the stolen-MC-number discussion when building your identity incident file.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: consider your carrier identity, account access, and document distribution together when reviewing available services.
lfsshield.com

5
The link is part of the load offer



An expected business task can arrive through an unexpected and unsafe route.

“The rate confirmation is attached.” “Finish setup here.” “Your load board session expired.” Those messages fit the workday. That's why they deserve attention. A person doesn't have to persuade you to do something unusual if they can attach a false sign-in page to something you already need to do.

This chapter helps you handle a message without giving it more access than it has earned. The same habits apply to email, texts, QR codes, shared documents, and chat messages.

Look beyond the display name

An inbox may show “Customer Accounting” while hiding the full address. Expand the sender details. Compare the actual address with the approved contact record. Watch for changed spellings, added words, or a different reply-to address. A correct-looking address is useful evidence, but it isn't a complete check.

The FBI describes business email compromise involving look-alike addresses, compromised accounts, and fraudulent payment requests. It recommends independently checking payment or account changes and using multifactor authentication. A message inside a real conversation can still be unauthorized. [S12]

Don't decide by grammar alone. A scam can be well written. A legitimate customer can write a rushed message with spelling mistakes. The important questions are whether the request was expected, whether the sender is authorized, and whether the action belongs in your normal process.

Use your own route to the service

If a message says your load board or document account requires attention, open the service through your saved bookmark or independently known address. Sign in there and check whether the request exists. Don't use the message's link as the only route to a login page.

Inspecting a link can reveal a mismatch, but a plausible address doesn't make a link safe. Shortened links, redirects, and unfamiliar subdomains complicate the picture. On a phone, the visible text may conceal most of the destination. If the business task can be completed through the known portal, use that route.

A QR code is another way to supply a link. It doesn't become trustworthy because it appears on a rate confirmation or shipping

notice. Apply the same rule: establish the source and use the approved service directly when possible.

Requests that should stop the interaction

Don't provide a password, recovery code, or one-time sign-in code to a caller who says they need it to release a load. Don't approve an authentication prompt you didn't initiate. Don't install remote-control software so an unknown “support” person can fix your booking problem.

If a document tells you to disable security settings or enable unfamiliar active content to read a rate, stop. Obtain the document through a verified contact and approved method. Your company should decide which file types and sharing systems it accepts before a dispatcher is under pressure.

You may legitimately be asked to authorize an application to access an account. That is still an access decision. The person responsible for company systems should review the requested permissions and the business need. A button labeled “Continue” can authorize more than simply opening a file.

Don't turn a suspicious file into a group project

Forwarding an attachment to every coworker with “Does this look fake?” creates more opportunities for someone to open it. Use your company's reporting method. Preserve the original message without requiring ordinary staff to execute, preview, or test the file.

If you don't have technical staff, arrange a support contact before an incident. Ask what they need preserved and how they want suspicious material transferred. A public file-analysis website may expose business or personal information submitted to it; don't upload customer documents or carrier packets without understanding the service and your authority to share them.

The person reporting the message should not have to prove that it contains malware. A clear description of the unexpected request is enough to start a review. “It asked me to sign in again and approve a new app” is more useful than “The email seemed weird.”

If you already interacted

Tell the responsible person immediately and describe the action precisely: opened the message, followed a link, downloaded a file, ran a file, entered a password, approved a prompt, or sent documents. Those are different events and may require different responses.

Use a separate trusted route to contact support. If an account may be compromised, have the administrator review sessions, connected applications, mail forwarding, and recovery settings, as well as credentials. If money or freight instructions may have been altered, notify the operations and finance leads at the same time. Technical cleanup alone won't correct a false delivery instruction already sent to a driver.

Don't wipe a device or delete the conversation in an attempt to tidy up. Follow your incident lead's instructions for evidence and containment. If you suspect active remote access, contact qualified support promptly and use a separate device for sensitive communications.

Practice case: the familiar thread

In a fictional case, an existing email conversation suddenly contains a link to a “new carrier compliance portal.” It requests your company email password and a one-time code. The sender's address matches the customer you know.

Would matching the address make this request acceptable? What would you do next?

No. The requested credentials and code are themselves a serious problem, and a real account may be compromised. Stop the sign-in attempt. Contact the customer through the established independent route and report the message internally. If credentials or codes were already supplied, start the account-response process immediately rather than waiting for confirmation that someone used them.

One change to make now

Write down the approved route for reporting suspicious messages and the person who can revoke account access. Test the reporting route with a harmless training message. Staff should be able to find it without searching an inbox that may itself be compromised.

Freight Broker Complaint: connect email compromise with the freight consequences described in its cyber-enabled cargo-theft article.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: review its current scope for email and file concerns; confirm how confidential material is handled before submitting it.
lfsshield.com

6
Paperwork needs a source



A document can be useful without being proof that every claim in it is true.

A carrier packet can arrive in a few seconds. It may contain a tax form, authority information, insurance certificate, references, and payment instructions. Each document answers a different question. None should be treated as a universal certificate of honesty.

Your job is to identify what the document claims, who can confirm that claim, and whether you need to share the information being requested in return.

Start with the purpose

Before sending a document, ask what the recipient needs it for and whether that recipient has been verified. A legitimate setup process may need a W-9 and insurance information. That doesn't mean every person asking for a “complete packet” needs a driver's license image, bank statement, or account login.

Create a company list of standard setup documents and who may release them. Keep more sensitive material in a separate process. This gives an administrator something concrete to follow instead of deciding from scratch every time a customer asks for “everything.”

Use the minimum information needed for the legitimate task. Where a redacted copy is appropriate and accepted, make the redaction permanent before sharing. Drawing a black rectangle over editable text may leave the underlying information recoverable. Never alter information that must remain accurate for the document's intended use.

A W-9 is not identity verification

A completed tax form provides claimed taxpayer information. A copy can be stolen or altered. It doesn't establish that the sender controls the business, that a shipment exists, or that the bank account in the next attachment belongs to the payee.

Compare the legal name across the agreement, official records where applicable, and invoice instructions. A DBA can be legitimate, but document the relationship. If the names differ, resolve the difference rather than typing whichever version fits the accounting system.

Avoid collecting sensitive tax or personal information just to feel more certain. More data in your folder doesn't necessarily improve

the verification, and it creates another record your company must handle responsibly.

Verify insurance through the issuer

An insurance certificate is a summary document. It is not a substitute for reading the relevant policy and endorsements, and its presence does not establish that every proposed loss would be covered. For an important coverage question, involve your insurance professional. FMCSA's filing requirements are a separate registration reference, not a substitute for the policy. [S19]

Confirm the issuing agency or insurer through an independently established contact route. Don't rely only on the phone number printed on the questionable certificate. Ask about the named insured, policy dates, relevant coverage, and whether the document was issued by that office. The issuer may require authorization before discussing details.

Match the coverage question to the shipment. Commodity, value, operating territory, exclusions, deductibles, and conditions can matter. "They have a million dollars" is too vague to decide whether the contemplated work fits. Liability limits and cargo coverage are different subjects; one number should not stand in for the other.

Record what the issuer actually confirmed. If the agent confirmed that a certificate was issued but did not answer whether a particular commodity was covered, write that limitation down. Don't convert a partial answer into a broad coverage conclusion.

Changes deserve their own review

A revised certificate, newly added payee, or replacement agreement can be legitimate. It can also change the transaction materially. Compare the new version with the old one. Look at names, dates, addresses, limits, exclusions noted, signatures, and payment terms—not just the logo at the top.

Keep the earlier version in the historical file. Label the new version with its received date and the reason it replaced the old one. A clean audit trail shows what staff relied on at the time; silently replacing files can erase that explanation.

For a signed agreement, make sure the person signing for your carrier has authority to do so. A dispatcher should not accept new indemnity, payment, or assignment terms merely to make a setup screen turn green. Route unfamiliar terms to the owner or designated reviewer.

Share documents through a controlled route

Confirm the recipient address before sending. Use the company's approved transfer system and access settings. A link that anyone can open is different from a link limited to named recipients. An expiration date can reduce ongoing access, but it does not recall a copy already downloaded.

Keep a distribution note for sensitive documents: what was sent, to whom, for which purpose, when, and under whose approval. If a packet later appears in an unauthorized load, that note may help narrow the investigation. It won't prove which recipient misused it; accounts and devices can be compromised too.

Practice case: a certificate and a new account

A fictional customer asks your administrator to send an updated certificate and tax form to a new “setup specialist.” The message also requests a voided check and a photograph of the owner's driver's license. The specialist's address hasn't been confirmed.

Which part of the request can you fulfill immediately? What questions belong in the next conversation?

Don't release the requested packet to the unverified recipient. Confirm the specialist through the established customer route, establish the legitimate purpose for each item, and use the approved transfer method. The certificate and tax form may fit normal setup; the banking and personal identification requests need separate review. Their inclusion in one email does not give them equal justification.

Finish with a usable record

Your document register should let another employee answer four questions: Which version did we use? Who supplied it? What did we independently confirm? Who received our documents? If the answers are buried in someone's personal inbox, the process still depends too heavily on that person's memory.

Freight Broker Complaint: its stolen-identity discussion is relevant when a genuine carrier packet appears in an unauthorized transaction.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: check document-review and confidential-file handling options against your company's actual sharing process.
lfsshield.com

7
When the rate or payment changes the conversation



A profitable-looking load still needs a verified transaction behind it.

A good rate can make a dispatcher feel that the remaining questions are details. An advance payment can make the deal feel even safer. But the amount offered doesn't establish who is offering it, and a deposit appearing in an account doesn't answer every question about the funds.

This chapter is about money used to move a decision forward before the facts are ready. It also separates ordinary commercial charges from requests that don't belong in the transaction.

Price the load before you judge the offer

Know what the proposed work actually requires: loaded and empty miles, equipment, appointments, commodity, weight, accessorials, expected waiting time, and operating costs. A rate that seems high may include expenses you haven't recognized. A rate that seems normal can still come from an impersonator.

Use your own operating numbers and current lane information. Don't let the sender define both the rate and the comparison. Keep the pricing decision separate from the identity decision. “It pays enough” doesn't answer “Who is hiring us?”

FMCSA's fraud guidance tells carriers to stop a transaction when a broker quickly agrees to pay more or when a rate far exceeds the current market. It also directs a stop when a questioned destination is dismissed as a blind load, or the driver is asked to misrepresent the carrier. These are agency prevention instructions, not a finding that each situation proves a crime. [S7]

An advance can create a new request

A fictional sender offers to prepay $8,000 for transportation quoted at $5,500. The extra $2,500 is supposedly for a warehouse representative, and the sender asks your carrier to forward it immediately. You are no longer simply receiving freight payment. You're being asked to move money for someone whose authority and payment may be uncertain.

The FTC explains that a bank can make deposited check funds available before discovering a check is fake. Availability does not establish that the check is valid. Overpayment requests commonly ask the recipient to send part of the deposit elsewhere. [S13]

Don't use a stranger's check as the basis for a refund, third-party transfer, gift-card purchase, or cryptocurrency payment. Contact your bank through its established fraud or business banking

channel if a suspicious payment arrives. Ask the bank how to handle it. Don't independently “return” money to a new account supplied by the sender.

Fees need a business reason and an authorized payee

Freight can involve legitimate lumper charges, permits, tolls, advances, and other expenses. The existence of real fees gives a false fee a familiar name. Confirm what the charge is for, who is responsible under the agreement, who receives it, and how it is normally paid.

A demand to pay an unknown individual to “release” a load should not be treated as a routine carrier expense. Neither should a request to send payment outside an established platform because the platform is “temporarily down.” Stop the proposed payment and verify through the authorized contracting party.

For a legitimate charge at a facility, obtain the authorized instructions and receipt through your normal process. A receipt image sent by the requester doesn't prove the recipient is entitled to the money. Your driver shouldn't be left to settle a disputed fee using a personal account just to keep the dock moving.

Urgency belongs in the record

“The truck has to leave in ten minutes” may describe a real operating constraint. It can also be used to prevent review. Write down the deadline and the unresolved issue. Give your decision-maker both facts rather than presenting the deadline as a reason verification is impossible.

Use a simple response: “The payment request needs approval through our usual contact. We can't send it based on this message.” There is no need to argue about whether the sender is a scammer. The rule applies to the action.

If a manager decides to decline the proposed work, record the reason neutrally: identity unconfirmed, payment recipient unresolved, or requested carrier misrepresentation. Avoid labels your evidence cannot support. You may later learn that a legitimate company was being impersonated.

Credit risk is a separate problem

A verified customer can still pay late, dispute a charge, or become insolvent. Identity checks do not replace credit review, clear terms, or collection procedures. Likewise, a factor's willingness to buy an invoice does not authenticate every person in the load chain or guarantee every dispute will be paid.

Understand your factoring agreement, including recourse, reserves, disputed invoices, assignments, and notice requirements. Ask the factor about a questionable debtor or instruction through your existing contact route. Don't assume that someone using the factor's name is authorized to change where money goes.

Practice case: the fast agreement

In a fictional negotiation, you ask for an additional $900 because the lane doesn't fit your costs. The broker immediately offers $1,800 more if you send a “capacity reservation” payment to a personal account before receiving the full pickup details.

Identify the separate decisions hidden in this offer. What should your staff do now?

There is a rate decision, an identity and authority decision, a proposed advance expense, a payee decision, and an incomplete shipment instruction. Stop the transaction and escalate. The added money doesn't answer any of the missing questions. Verify the company and load through independent routes; do not send the reservation payment while trying to resolve the offer.

The correct training answer is not “accept if the rate is high enough to cover the fee.” That calculation assumes the payment and shipment are real—the very facts still in question.

Keep one rule visible

Any request that sends your carrier's money to a new recipient needs its own authorization and independent confirmation. It shouldn't slip through because it arrived in a load conversation instead of an accounting conversation. Put the rule where dispatch, drivers, and accounts staff can all see it.

Freight Broker Complaint: use its fraud-statistics discussion as context, while checking the original sources and categories explained at the front of this book.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: include unusual advance-payment and fee requests when evaluating a transaction-review process.
lfsshield.com

8
Pickup is an identity checkpoint



The truck at the dock must match the authorized transportation arrangement.

The office can perform careful checks and still lose control at pickup. A substituted driver arrives. A stranger has the pickup number. The shipping clerk sees familiar paperwork and releases the trailer. By the time someone asks which carrier actually collected it, the answer may be scattered across several systems.

Pickup deserves its own check. This chapter explains what dispatch should send, what the driver should confirm, and how the facility can help establish who took custody.

Give the driver a complete instruction

The driver needs the authorized pickup facility, appointment, reference numbers, commodity information appropriate to the work, and the carrier's dispatch contact. The driver also needs to know what to do when the facility gives a different instruction.

Use one current dispatch record rather than several conflicting texts. If you revise it, identify the change and make sure the driver acknowledges the current version when safely stopped. A long message chain is a poor substitute for a clear final instruction.

Tell the driver which company name to use truthfully. If the pickup paperwork shows a different carrier or the clerk expects a different truck, the driver should report the discrepancy before accepting freight. Don't tell the driver to improvise an explanation that the office hasn't verified.

A pickup number is not a complete identity check

Reference numbers help locate a shipment. They can be copied, forwarded, photographed, or exposed through an account compromise. Possession of the number should not be the only reason a facility releases a valuable load.

Coordinate with the shipper or broker in advance about the authorized driver and equipment information the facility requires. Share personal details only through approved channels and only as needed. The facility's process may include driver identification, carrier identity, tractor and trailer information, and an appointment match.

The carrier should keep its own record of the assigned driver and equipment. A last-minute substitution needs approval and a clear update to the relevant parties. An unexplained message saying “different truck coming” is a change to review, not a clerical detail to ignore.

Record what actually happened

The load file should connect the authorized arrangement with the actual pickup. Preserve the bill of lading, seal information where used, pickup time, equipment identifiers, and any exception noted at the facility. Follow customer requirements and applicable rules for the shipment.

Photos can help document condition or identifiers when permitted and safe. They do not replace a written record or establish everything outside the frame. Don't photograph restricted areas or personal identification without a legitimate need and appropriate permission. Keep business evidence in the company system, not on a public social account.

If a document is wrong, request a correction through the authorized parties. Don't erase the original and create a cleaner-looking history. A dated correction that explains the discrepancy is more useful than a file that conceals it.

Understand a seal's limits

A seal number can help connect pickup and delivery records. A matching seal does not prove that every earlier instruction was authorized, and a seal discrepancy doesn't identify who caused it. Treat a missing, changed, or damaged seal as an exception requiring the carrier's established process.

The driver should not break or replace a seal simply because a new caller asks. Confirm the reason and authority through dispatch and the appropriate customer contact. When a legitimate inspection or facility procedure requires opening, record who authorized it, when it happened, and any replacement seal information.

Commodity requirements matter. Temperature-controlled freight, food, pharmaceuticals, and other specialized loads may require

additional procedures. This chapter is an identity and custody lesson, not a replacement for those operating requirements.

Keep the driver safe during a disagreement

A driver should not physically confront a suspected impersonator or block another vehicle to investigate. Notify dispatch and facility management. If there is immediate danger or an active theft, contact emergency services or local law enforcement as appropriate.

The office should handle authority questions without making the driver the messenger between arguing companies. Tell the driver what is paused, who is resolving it, and when to expect an update. Include a safe plan for waiting, parking, and hours-of-service constraints.

Don't pressure a driver to sign inaccurate paperwork to avoid detention. A signature can become important evidence later. If the document doesn't reflect what occurred, follow the carrier's exception process and obtain direction from the responsible manager.

Practice case: the substitute truck

A fictional warehouse calls your office. A driver has arrived with the correct pickup number and a copy of your rate confirmation, but your assigned driver is still an hour away. The arriving truck displays another carrier's name. The caller asks whether to release the load because the dock is busy.

What should you say, and what records should you preserve?

Tell the facility that your carrier has not authorized that pickup and ask it to pause release while the authorized parties resolve the discrepancy. Confirm the information through the facility's known contact route. Notify the verified broker or shipper, preserve the assignment record and messages, and record the facility's

observations. Let facility management and law enforcement handle any confrontation or suspected active theft.

Don't assume the other carrier knowingly participated. Its identity, documents, or driver may also have been misled. Report the observed mismatch and the absence of authorization rather than an unsupported conclusion about intent.

A pre-pickup conversation worth having

Ask a regular customer: “What happens if someone arrives with our pickup number but a different carrier name?” Their answer tells you whether the last checkpoint is a real identity process or just a reference-number lookup. Agree on a method before the next substitution request arrives.

Freight Broker Complaint: use the cargo-theft article to discuss how an electronic deception can become a physical pickup.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: consider how digital transaction review connects to the actual driver and equipment release process.
lfsshield.com

9
A new destination is a new decision



Park safely, call the established contact, and resolve the change before acting on it.

The truck is loaded. Then a message arrives: the receiver is full, the original warehouse is closed, the customer wants a different location, or a “recovery team” will take the trailer. Real transportation plans change. That fact gives a false change a believable explanation.

Your task is to establish who can authorize the new instruction and whether the new receiving arrangement is legitimate. The fact that freight is already moving makes that check more urgent, not less necessary.

Decide who may change a load

Before pickup, identify the customer's authorized change contact and the carrier's internal approver. Include an after-hours route. A driver should know that a text from an unfamiliar number does not replace dispatch instructions.

Define the changes that require review: delivery address, receiving company, appointment, trailer exchange, transload, seal handling, driver, equipment, or payment connected with release. Some changes affect contracts, insurance, security, and operating feasibility at the same time.

Don't make the driver interpret all of that. The driver reports the request and follows the carrier's safe hold process. The responsible office personnel establish the authority and document the decision.

Confirm more than the street address

A real warehouse address doesn't prove that the shipment belongs there. A map result doesn't show that the caller can direct your freight. Establish the receiving entity, the reason for the change, the person accepting delivery, and the authorized customer's approval.

Use the known customer contact route. Ask for written instructions through the approved channel after the independent confirmation. Written instructions are part of the record; they are not a substitute for authenticating the person issuing them.

Check the operational consequences before agreeing. Can the driver reach the new location legally and safely? Is the appointment confirmed? Does the route fit the equipment and commodity? Who addresses additional mileage, waiting, or other charges? A verified change still needs workable transportation terms.

“Blind” doesn't mean nobody can answer

Commercial arrangements may limit which parties see certain customer information. That does not excuse an unresolved question about where the carrier is being told to deliver or who is authorized to receive the freight. The carrier needs sufficient verified instructions to perform the transportation responsibly.

If questioning the destination produces only “it's a blind load,” stop the affected transaction and escalate under the FMCSA guidance described in Chapter 7. Do not turn commercial confidentiality into permission to deliver to an unverified location.

You can say, “We need our authorized contact to confirm the delivery instruction and receiving party. We can handle confidential information through the agreed process.” That keeps the conversation focused on the missing approval.

Watch for a handoff disguised as help

A caller may offer another truck to “save the appointment” or ask the driver to leave the trailer in a lot for a recovery carrier. A legitimate recovery can occur, but it changes custody. It requires the same careful identification and authorization as the original pickup.

Record who approved the transfer, which company and equipment will receive the freight, where it will occur, and how custody will be documented. Consult the carrier's responsible manager and insurance professional when the change raises coverage or contract questions.

Never let a caller's possession of the load number become the whole authorization. By this stage many people may know that number. A message that accurately repeats the commodity or original receiver can still contain a false new instruction.

If the driver has already changed course

Tell dispatch immediately. Record the time of the message, the number or account used, what the driver was told, and the current safe location. The office should contact the verified customer and determine whether the instruction was authorized.

If the driver is at an unfamiliar location and feels unsafe, personal safety comes first. Contact emergency services when warranted. Do not ask the driver to confront people, retrieve freight by force, or stay in a threatening situation to gather evidence.

If freight has already been transferred, preserve the delivery or handoff records and start the incident process. Prompt factual reporting is more useful than debating whose fault it was while messages and camera footage disappear.

Practice case: the receiver's text

In a fictional situation, a text says the booked receiver's dock is unavailable. It gives a nearby address and says the same company operates both buildings. The message includes the correct load number. Your driver is ten minutes from the original receiver.

List what you would verify before authorizing the change. Then explain why checking the new address on a map isn't enough.

Confirm the request through the established authorized customer contact, the identity of the new receiving party, its ability and authority to accept this shipment, the appointment, and the written change instruction. Review the carrier's operating and contractual implications. The map can show a building; it cannot establish the caller's authority or the customer's consent.

While that happens, direct the driver through the safe waiting process. Don't tell the driver to unload first and let accounting sort it out. Delivery changes concern custody and authority, not just invoice details.

Close the change record

After a legitimate change, keep the original instruction, the request, the independent confirmation, the approval, and the revised instruction together. Record when the driver received it. That sequence explains why the truck went somewhere different from the original rate confirmation.

If the change was unauthorized, preserve it as evidence and tell the relevant legitimate parties through verified channels. One carrier's timely report may help them stop the same instruction from reaching another driver.

Freight Broker Complaint: use its cyber-enabled cargo-theft discussion when reviewing an unauthorized delivery or custody change.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: evaluate how a proposed service handles changed instructions, rather than assuming an earlier approval covers the rest of the load.
lfsshield.com

10
Getting paid into the right account



A payment change needs its own verification, even after a legitimate delivery.

The freight can reach the correct receiver and the carrier can still lose the payment. A changed invoice, a false notice of assignment, or an email from a compromised account can redirect money after the transportation work is finished.

This chapter belongs to dispatch as well as accounting. The person who first receives a new payment instruction may be the same person who booked the load. They need to know where to route it and what they are not authorized to change.

Establish payment instructions at setup

Keep approved payee and payment information in a controlled record. Record how it was verified and who approved it. Separate the ability to enter a proposed change from the authority to release money under that change whenever staffing permits.

In a very small company, one person may do both jobs. Use a documented second review by the owner or another authorized person for consequential changes. If that is impossible, at least use an independent callback and a deliberate review outside the incoming message. A small staff is a reason to simplify the process, not leave it undefined.

Send your own invoices through a consistent route. Tell customers how your carrier communicates legitimate payment changes. Establish that a new account won't be accepted solely because an email says it is effective immediately. This helps the customer recognize a request that doesn't fit your process.

Treat a bank change as a fresh instruction

Don't rely on a reply to the email requesting the change. Call the approved contact using the existing number. Confirm the change with someone authorized to direct payments, then use your bank's and company's approved process for validating the new instructions.

Record the old and new instruction references without spreading full account numbers through general notes. Keep sensitive details where access is restricted. A change log can use masked identifiers and point to the controlled banking record.

Don't send a token payment just because the requester says it will “verify” the account. Whether a payment-validation method is appropriate should be decided with your bank and finance lead, not by the person asking for the transfer.

The FBI's business email compromise guidance says to contact your financial institution immediately if a fraudulent transfer occurs and ask it to contact the receiving institution. Also report to IC3. Speed matters, but recovery is not guaranteed. [S12]

Factoring adds a relationship to verify

A notice of assignment can legitimately direct a debtor to pay a factor. A release can legitimately change that instruction later. Both affect who receives money and should be handled through the carrier's established factoring and accounting process.

Verify the notice with the known factor and carrier contacts through independent routes. Compare the legal names, invoice scope, effective date, and instructions. If competing notices arrive, stop the disputed change and obtain qualified help. Don't decide ownership of a receivable by choosing the most recent email.

Read your agreement before assuming a factor absorbs every loss. Recourse, disputed invoices, reserves, and other terms can affect the carrier's responsibility. Factoring is a financial arrangement, not proof that the freight transaction or every document is genuine.

Match the invoice to the work

Before invoicing, compare the load number, contracting party, agreed rate, authorized accessorials, proof of delivery, and payment terms. Keep supporting records together. An unexplained change in the invoice recipient should be reviewed, even if the freight moved normally.

If the customer disputes payment, ask for a specific explanation and compare it with the agreement and records. Late payment, a disputed detention charge, and an impersonation scheme are different problems. Describe the facts accurately so the next person can choose the correct response.

Do not alter a proof of delivery or manufacture a signature to make an invoice acceptable. If a document is missing or inaccurate, resolve the exception openly through the authorized parties. A false correction can create a new problem larger than the original paperwork issue.

Know the record right without inventing a remedy

49 CFR 371.3(c) states: “Each party to a brokered transaction has the right to review the record of the transaction required to be kept by these rules.” [S14]

The section specifies broker transaction records and a three-year retention period. It does not, by itself, promise immediate payment, establish that a complaint will recover money, or resolve every contract dispute. Consult the current rule and qualified advice about your circumstances, including any contested contractual terms.

A clear records request identifies the transaction, your role, and the records sought. Keep proof of the request and response. Don't turn the request into an unsupported accusation that every withheld or delayed item proves fraud.

Practice case: the Friday notice

A fictional email arrives late Friday from the usual carrier contact. It says the carrier has left its factor and asks your accounts employee to pay a new bank account that afternoon. The attached letter contains a signature and the correct invoice numbers.

What is the safest next business action? What evidence would support a later change?

Pause the disputed payment instruction. Contact the carrier and factor through established routes, verify the assignment or release and the authorized payee, and follow the finance approval process. Correct invoice numbers and a signature image don't resolve

competing payment rights. Keep the request, confirmation, and approval together if the change is established.

If a transfer has already gone out and fraud is suspected, contact the bank immediately rather than waiting for the sender to explain. Preserve transaction references and start the reporting process in Chapter 11.

Close the file without losing the trail

Keep the final invoice, delivery evidence, authorized changes, remittance information, and any dispute correspondence together. Your retention schedule should account for applicable law, contracts, insurance, and litigation holds. Don't apply the broker's three-year rule indiscriminately as the only retention rule for every carrier record.

Freight Broker Complaint: compare its broker-transparency article with the exact current regulation before making a transaction-record request.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: include invoice and account-change messages in your review process; confirm any service's current capabilities and handling of banking information.
lfsshield.com

11
Something happened. Start with the facts.



A calm timeline helps the bank, customer, insurer, and authorities understand the same event.

Maybe you sent the packet. Maybe someone entered a password. Maybe a truck followed a false instruction. The first useful question is what happened, followed by what is still exposed. Blame can wait. Money, access, and freight may still be moving.

This chapter gives you an order of work. Several actions may need to happen at the same time, so appoint one incident lead to keep the record and assign responsibilities.

Address the immediate exposure

If someone is in danger or an active theft requires an emergency response, contact 911 or the appropriate local emergency service. Don't send employees to confront suspects or recover freight themselves.

If money was sent, contact the bank or payment provider immediately through an established channel. Give the transaction reference, amount, time, destination details, and reason you suspect fraud. Request the available recall, hold, or fraud-response steps. Record the case number and instructions. A complaint filed elsewhere does not replace this call.

If an account may be compromised, contact the administrator or qualified technical support through a trusted route. If freight is affected, contact the carrier's operations lead and the verified contracting parties. Give the driver a safe, clear instruction while the authority question is resolved.

These actions should not wait until the entire story is understood. You can report what you know and label what remains uncertain.

Preserve originals and build a timeline

Keep original emails with headers, attachments, text messages, call logs, rate confirmations, agreements, bills of lading, delivery records, payment references, and relevant account notices. Screenshots supplement these records; they don't replace every original.

Record times with time zones. “Around lunch” is less useful than “12:18 p.m. Central, based on the message timestamp.” Distinguish the time an event occurred from the time your company discovered it. If a time is estimated, say so.

Store a working copy separately from the preserved original. Restrict access to people who need it. Keep a simple evidence

index showing the file name, source, date received, and who collected it. Follow professional advice when formal evidence handling or a legal hold is needed.

Don't delete embarrassing messages, edit an original to make it clearer, or fill a gap with an assumption. Add an explanatory note. A truthful incomplete record is more useful than a polished inaccurate one.

Separate observations from conclusions

Write “The email used this domain” rather than “This company stole the load” unless the evidence actually establishes that conclusion. Write “Our authorized driver did not make this pickup” rather than claiming to know the intent of a different driver.

The legitimate broker, carrier, employee, or shipper whose identity appears in the records may also be a victim. Contact them through independent channels. Give them enough specific information to locate the event without spreading unnecessary personal or banking data.

If public notice is needed, have the responsible person review it for accuracy and privacy. State the unauthorized use or disputed instruction clearly. Avoid publishing personal identification, full bank details, passwords, or unsupported accusations. Preserve a private evidence package for the appropriate recipients.

Use the appropriate reporting routes

For internet-enabled fraud, file with the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center at ic3.gov. For scams and suspicious business communications, the FTC accepts reports at ReportFraud.ftc.gov. These reports serve different functions from a bank's attempt to stop a transfer. [S15, S16]

For FMCSA-related registration fraud or identity issues, use the current FMCSA Complaint Center and contact FMCSA at 1-800-832-5660. The older fraud page refers to NCCDB; begin at the current complaint portal rather than relying on an old bookmark. DOT's Office of Inspector General accepts hotline reports at 800-424-9071 and through its official site. [S17, S18]

Report to local law enforcement where appropriate and obtain a report number. Notify your insurer promptly under the policy's notice requirements, and contact relevant load boards, factors, and affected customers through verified routes. Ask each recipient what additional material it needs and record the response.

An independent platform such as Freight Broker Complaint can provide another reporting or documentation route. It is not a government agency, and submitting there is not a substitute for official reports, timely insurance notice, or legal action when required.

Do not use freight as a collection tool

FMCSA's fraud page says: “Holding loads hostage until you get paid is illegal.” [S7]

If you discover a fraudulently arranged load, coordinate with the legitimate parties and obtain qualified advice. Do not threaten to withhold or dispose of cargo to force payment. A carrier can be unpaid and still have obligations concerning the freight. This book doesn't attempt to decide lien rights or remedies for an individual dispute.

Practice case: three problems at once

In a fictional incident, an administrator entered an email password into a false portal. Later, accounting sent a payment based on a changed instruction, and dispatch received a new delivery address from the same email thread. The truck has not yet unloaded.

Name the three immediate workstreams and the person who should coordinate them.

Account response, bank/payment response, and freight/operations response must proceed together. Assign an incident lead to maintain the timeline and connect the teams. Pause the unverified delivery change through a safe driver instruction, contact the bank immediately, and have qualified support address account access. Preserve the messages and report through the relevant channels. Waiting for the technical investigation to finish could leave the money and freight exposed.

End the day with a handoff

List what has been stopped, what remains unresolved, who owns each next action, and when the next update is due. Include bank and agency case numbers. The night shift should not have to reconstruct an incident from scattered texts while the day shift sleeps.

Freight Broker Complaint: use its filing guide to organize a factual account and supporting records.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: check current incident-review assistance and response arrangements; use emergency, banking, and official reporting routes without waiting for a private service.
lfsshield.com

12
Make the process work on a busy day



A process works when the next person can follow it without guessing.

A checklist can look excellent in a quiet office and disappear when three trucks need loads. The answer isn't a longer checklist. It's a small set of clear decisions, named owners, and records people can complete during real work.

This chapter turns the book into an operating habit. The carrier owner sets the standard. Dispatch, administration, accounts, and drivers each carry a part of it.

Give every consequential action an owner

Name the person who approves new trading relationships, the person who reviews document requests, the person who approves payment changes, and the person who handles incidents. Identify a backup for absences and after-hours work.

One person may fill several roles, but the roles should still be visible. “Everybody handles it” often means nobody knows whether it was done. The file should show the person who completed the check and the person who approved an exception, if exceptions are permitted.

Some rules should have no routine exception: don't misrepresent the carrier, don't share authentication codes, and don't follow an unverified delivery or bank change. Write those boundaries plainly. A senior employee shouldn't be able to bypass them casually while expecting a new hire to follow them.

Use three honest statuses

Pending means a required fact has not been established. Cleared for a specific action means the required checks for that action are complete. Stopped means a discrepancy or prohibited request prevents that action from proceeding.

Avoid a single permanent “trusted” label for a company. A customer can be approved for ordinary bookings while a new bank instruction remains pending. A load can have verified pickup instructions while a proposed delivery change is stopped.

Record the scope and date of the decision. “Cleared to send standard setup documents to the confirmed procurement address” says more than a green checkmark next to the company name. It also prevents a later employee from assuming that the same approval covers personal identification or banking records.

Make a hold practical

A hold should name the action being paused, the unresolved fact, the person resolving it, and the next review time. Without those details, a hold becomes a vague warning that busy staff may ignore.

For example: “Do not send banking documents. New recipient has not been confirmed. Office manager will call the established customer contact by 2 p.m.” That's workable. “Seems suspicious” is not enough direction for the next employee.

For a loaded truck, include the safe operating plan and driver contact. A business hold doesn't excuse unsafe parking, missed safety duties, or silence toward the driver. The operations manager needs to manage those consequences while the authority question is resolved.

Train with ordinary situations

Use the exercises in this book during short team discussions. Ask each person to identify the next action, the independent source, and the record they would keep. Don't reward someone merely for saying “scam” quickly.

Include legitimate explanations in practice. A customer may really change warehouses. A carrier may really replace a phone number. A factor may really issue a release. The skill is confirming the change without skipping the process or accusing people prematurely.

Use invented documents and addresses for training. Never ask employees to enter real passwords into a simulation or send live banking details as a test. Tell them how to report an unexpected request and make the reporting experience constructive.

Review a few files, not just a policy binder

Each week, select a small sample of new customers, material changes, and stopped transactions. Can another employee reconstruct the decision from the file? Are pending items still pending, or did someone quietly proceed? Are contact sources documented?

Look for process failures before individual blame. If every dispatcher skips a field because the system hides it, fix the workflow. If an after-hours callback route never answers, establish a usable route or adjust what work can be accepted at that hour.

Track near misses separately from losses. A reported suspicious request that was stopped is useful information, not evidence that the reporter caused trouble. If staff expect punishment for raising a concern, you'll receive fewer reports without necessarily having fewer incidents.

Choose tools by the decision they support

A service may help review an email, compare records, organize evidence, or flag a change. Ask what it actually checks, what data it uses, how current the data is, what it cannot establish, and how a person reviews an uncertain result.

Ask how confidential records are stored, who can access them, and how to remove them when appropriate. Confirm costs, response times, and support arrangements before depending on a service during an incident. A marketing description isn't evidence that a feature has been tested with your workflow.

Keep human authorization visible. A tool's result can inform a decision, but it should not silently change a payment account, release freight, or approve a new recipient. Decide who reviews the result and how the reason is recorded.

A thirty-day implementation

During the first week, establish the contact list, approval roles, and reporting route. In the second, use the verification and change forms on live work and remove fields that duplicate information already controlled elsewhere. In the third, run a short practice incident involving dispatch and accounting. In the fourth, review a sample of files and correct the biggest recurring gap.

Keep the work small enough to finish. A usable callback list and a functioning payment-change rule are worth more than a large unfinished policy document.

Final practice: teach it back

Ask a new employee to explain what happens when a known customer sends a new delivery address from a new number. They should identify the safe pause, the independently selected contact route, the authorized confirmation, the operational review, and the recorded instruction to the driver.

Then ask what changes if the message concerns a bank account instead. The underlying questions remain: who is asking, what authority do they have, and what evidence supports this particular change? The responsible people and the records differ.

If your team can explain that clearly and perform it on a busy day, the book has become part of the business. Keep reviewing the process as your customers, staff, and systems change.

Freight Broker Complaint: use the article library for continuing discussions, checking legal and statistical claims against original sources.
freightbrokercomplaint.com

LFS Shield: assess current services against your written roles, escalation rules, and evidence needs before adopting a workflow.
lfsshield.com

Field forms

Copy these working forms for internal use. Keep completed records in controlled files. Use fictional data in training. A blank field never means “approved.”

A | New relationship and load verification

Prospect or company legal name / DBA

Claimed role: shipper, broker, carrier, dispatcher, other

USDOT / MC identifiers where applicable

Load reference, lane, commodity, equipment, dates

Original sender address and contact number

Independent source used to locate the company contact

Number called, date, time, and time zone

Person reached, role, and scope of authority confirmed

Specific shipment or request confirmed

Differences found in names, domains, numbers, or instructions

Documents reviewed and issuer checks completed

Unresolved facts / action currently paused

Decision, scope, reviewer, and next review date

State exactly which action is approved. Attach the supporting evidence; an approval checkmark alone is insufficient.

B | Callback and change record

Complete this for a changed contact, pickup, delivery, carrier, equipment, payee, or bank instruction. Keep the original instruction with the change record.

Load / invoice / customer reference

Original approved instruction and its source

Proposed change, requester, and received time

What would happen if the change were followed?

Independent contact route used; where it came from

Authorized person reached and exact confirmation received

What that person could not confirm

Operating, payment, contract, or coverage issues reviewed

Written confirmation location / file reference

Internal approver and approval time

Driver or accounts employee notified; acknowledgment time

Final status and reason

Do not put full bank account numbers in a broadly shared change log. Reference the controlled payment record. A callback to the new number supplied in the change request is not an independent check.

C | Pickup and custody check

Use this alongside your normal shipment documents and commodity procedures. It does not replace required bills of lading, inspection records, or customer instructions.

Load reference and authorized pickup facility

Assigned carrier, driver, tractor, and trailer identifiers

Appointment and approved facility contact

Actual arrival and pickup times, including time zone

Match confirmed between assignment and actual pickup

Bill of lading / freight bill reference

Seal number and condition, if applicable

Exceptions, discrepancies, or substitute equipment

Independent confirmation and person authorizing any change

Photos or other evidence retained, where permitted

Driver acknowledgment of current delivery instruction

Reviewer and completed time

If the carrier name or driver differs, pause release and resolve the difference. A correct pickup number alone is not the answer. Keep the original exception visible even after a legitimate correction.

D | Document-sharing register

Use one entry for each sensitive transfer. The purpose is to identify what left the company and why. It is not proof that a recipient caused any later misuse.

Document name, version, and date

Business purpose for the request

Recipient organization, individual, and verified address

How recipient authority was confirmed

Information excluded or permanently redacted, if appropriate

Transfer method and access restrictions

Expiration or access review date, if supported

Internal approval and sender

Date and time sent

Location of the exact copy sent

Before sending, confirm that the file is the intended version and contains no unnecessary information. Check recipients individually. An address suggested by autocomplete may belong to someone with a similar name.

After sending, retain the distribution record in the controlled system. If a mistake occurs, notify the responsible person promptly; a recall request may not remove copies already received.

E | Incident intake and handoff

Record known facts first. Use “unknown” or “estimated” where appropriate. Don't wait for every field before contacting the bank or emergency services.

Incident lead and trusted callback number

Discovery date, time, time zone, and reporter

Event dates and times, with source of each timestamp

Immediate safety concern / driver and freight location

Money sent: amount, method, time, transaction reference

Accounts or devices involved; actions actually taken

Documents or information shared

Verified legitimate parties notified

Bank, insurer, police, agency, and platform case numbers

Evidence index location and access owner

Actions completed, by whom, and when

Open actions, responsible person, and next update time

Handoff sentence: “The payment recall is pending with the bank; the driver has not unloaded; the account administrator has revoked the affected session; the customer confirmation call remains open.” Use actual facts, not this example, in a live incident.

F | Evidence index

Preserve originals. Use a separate working copy for annotation. Restrict sensitive material and follow legal or professional instructions when they apply.

Item number and descriptive file name

Source: email, text, document, system record, photo, other

Original creation or message time, if known

Date collected and person collecting it

Where the original is stored

What the item shows, stated factually

Limitations: missing pages, estimated time, partial screenshot

Who received a copy and for what purpose

Example: “E-04, delivery-change-text.png. Screenshot from driver's company phone, collected 3:12 p.m. Eastern. Shows a new address sent from an unapproved number. Original message retained on device. Screenshot does not establish the sender's identity.”

Keep a separate event timeline that references these item numbers. That allows a reviewer to move from a statement to its supporting record without searching every attachment.

If a record is corrected, preserve the earlier version and explain the correction. Don't make evidence look more certain than it is.

G | Fifteen-minute team drill

Use this fictional situation: a new shipper inquiry offers recurring loads. The domain differs from the company's published domain. A setup link requests an email login. Later, a caller offers a higher rate if the carrier sends a small fee before receiving pickup details.

Ask one person to act as dispatcher, one as administrator, and one as the owner. No live accounts, real credentials, or actual payments are used.

Dispatcher: what action is paused, and why?

Administrator: which documents or credentials stay unsent?

Owner: which independent route will establish authority?

Team: what evidence belongs in the file?

Team: what would allow work to resume, if anything?

Team: which official reporting route fits an attempted online scam?

Answer discussion: pause the transaction; don't use the setup link or send the fee; verify the claimed company and request independently; preserve the inquiry and later requests. A genuine company confirming it did not issue the request is evidence to record. Lack of a response leaves the request unresolved. Neither situation justifies inventing a loss or accusing a named employee without evidence.

Finish by asking each person to find the company's actual incident contact and approved customer directory. If those resources are hard to find during a drill, fix that before the next busy shift.

The desk guide
When minutes matter

People and freight

Address immediate danger first. Call 911 or the appropriate local emergency service when needed. A driver should stop safely before handling calls or documents. Do not confront suspects, attempt a private recovery, or send freight to an unverified new location.

Contact the carrier's operations lead and the legitimate customer through established routes. State the current location, custody status, and exact disputed instruction. Make the safe waiting plan explicit.

Money

Call the bank or payment provider immediately through its known fraud or business-support route. Give the transaction reference and request available fraud-response action. Record the case number. Don't send another payment to “release,” “trace,” or “recover” the first one based on an unsolicited offer.

IC3 warns about people impersonating the complaint center and claims by outside parties that they can work with it to recover funds. Use the official site and independently verify any follow-up. A recovery promise can become a second scam. [S15]

Accounts

Tell the administrator exactly what happened: link opened, file run, password entered, code shared, permission granted, or message sent. Use a separate trusted route if the affected account can't be trusted. Follow qualified support instructions for containment and evidence.

Records and reports

Preserve originals, note times and time zones, and name an incident lead. Notify the insurer and affected platforms or trading parties promptly through verified routes. Filing one report doesn't automatically notify everyone else.

FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center: online crime reports.
www.ic3.gov

FTC: scams and suspicious communications.
reportfraud.ftc.gov

FMCSA Complaint Center: eligible motor-carrier and registration complaints.
complaint.fmcsa.dot.gov

FMCSA complaint eligibility and telephone filing: 1-888-368-7238, weekdays 8 a.m.–8 p.m. Eastern as listed at this edition's source check.
www.fmcsa.dot.gov

FMCSA Contact Center: 1-800-832-5660.
ask.fmcsa.dot.gov

DOT Office of Inspector General hotline: 800-424-9071.
www.oig.dot.gov

Private services may assist with documentation or review. They do not replace emergency response, a bank recall request, an insurance notice, or official reporting. Keep the relevant case numbers together.

Terms you will hear

Authority and identity

Broker: a person or business arranging transportation for compensation within the applicable legal definition. See the exact excerpt and qualifications in Chapter 3.

Bona fide agent: a term defined in 49 CFR 371.2. The actual continuing relationship, carrier direction, and allocation of traffic matter; a job title alone doesn't settle the status.

Carrier packet: a collection of setup documents. It contains claims and records to check, not a guarantee that the sender represents the carrier.

DBA: “doing business as,” a trade name that may differ from a legal entity's name. Establish the relationship rather than assuming two names identify the same party.

MC number: an FMCSA docket identifier associated with certain operating authorities. The number's existence does not establish current authority or authenticate the person using it.

USDOT number: an identifier used in FMCSA's records. Check the current record and requirements relevant to the proposed operation.

Messages and access

Domain: the name forming the main part of a website address or the portion after the @ in an email address. Similar spelling does not make two domains identical.

Display name: the label an email program shows for a sender. It can differ from the actual address.

Phishing: a deceptive request intended to obtain information, access, money, or an unsafe action, often presented as an ordinary message or sign-in task.

Business email compromise: fraud involving business communications, including impersonated or compromised accounts used to induce an unauthorized transaction.

Multifactor authentication: a sign-in process using more than one type of evidence. It helps reduce account risk, but approving an unexpected prompt or sharing a code can defeat the intended check.

Freight and payment

Custody: who physically holds or controls the freight at a particular point. Record authorized transfers and the evidence of what actually occurred.

Diversion: a change in where freight is sent. A diversion can be legitimate or unauthorized; confirm authority before acting.

Strategic cargo theft: theft using deception to obtain freight, such as an impersonated pickup. Research definitions may differ, so read the source before comparing statistics.

Notice of assignment: a notice concerning the transfer of rights to payment, often involving a factor. Verify its authenticity and scope through established contacts.

Recourse: a term describing circumstances in which responsibility can return to the carrier or seller under a financial agreement. Read the actual agreement rather than relying on a general label.

Proof of delivery: a record of delivery. Its details should match the actual event; it doesn't independently establish every party's authority earlier in the transaction.

Evidence and decisions

Independent confirmation: confirmation through a contact route selected separately from the questioned request. Calling the new number supplied in that request does not meet this definition.

Pending: a required fact is unresolved. It is not a quiet approval.

Verified for a specific action: the defined checks for that action are complete. It is not a permanent guarantee about the company or every later request.

Incident: an event requiring review or response. Calling something an incident does not automatically mean a crime or a loss has been established.

Sources and edition notes

Research checked October 28, 2026. The April and October 2025 reports remain dated research, not measurements through 2026. Regulations and service pages can change. Use the linked official source for the current text before making a legal or operating decision.

Bracketed source numbers in the book identify the entries below. Official sources support the legal, agency, and statistical statements. The recommended forms, scripts, and fictional practice cases are teaching material developed for this book; they are not government forms or agency endorsements.

Research and the supplied inquiries

S1 · Transportation Intermediaries Association, State of Fraud in the Industry, April 2025. Executive overview, Watchdog reporting discussion, and methodology; PDF pages 3, 8, and 13. Survey and reporting-system measures are identified separately in this book.
Open original source

S2 · American Transportation Research Institute, The Fight Against Cargo Theft: Insights from the Trucking Industry, October 2025. Original report preserved as attachment 1 in federal docket DOT-OST-2025-1326-0063. See printed page 19 for respondent groups and 30–31, Tables 10–12, for the cost model. Printed page numbers differ from PDF viewer numbers.
Open original source

S3 · American Trucking Associations, Cargo Theft. The strategic-theft growth statement is attributed there to CargoNet. This book does not claim access to CargoNet's underlying incident-level dataset or relabel the statistic as all freight fraud.
Open original source

S4 · Edgewell Personal Care, Locations. Published corporate contact information used for the limited domain comparison in Chapter 1. A domain difference requires confirmation; it is not a finding about who sent the inquiry.
Open original source

S5 · Inteva Products, Contact Us. Published domain and headquarters address used for Chapter 1's comparison. The matching address does not authenticate an email sender.
Open original source

S6 · Michael Thomas / Logistical Forwarding Solutions, How to Spot a Fake Shipper Scam. Author background and teaching context. Claims about later detection, domain age, intent, or outcomes are not treated here as independently established facts about the supplied inquiries.
Open original source

The two inquiry summaries are based on messages supplied by the author in the referenced research conversation. Personal names and full email addresses are omitted from the teaching cases. No investigation outcome, financial loss, or criminal finding has been added. The original messages should be retained privately with the author's source records.

Official rules and agency guidance

S7 · FMCSA, Broker and Carrier Fraud and Identity Theft, updated April 7, 2025. Agency prevention and response guidance, including stop conditions and the warning about holding loads hostage. Guidance is distinguished from codified regulation.
Open original source

S8 · FMCSA, Safety and Fitness Electronic Records system (SAFER). Company snapshots and public record checks. A record lookup does not authenticate every person using a company's identity.
Open original source

S9 · 49 CFR 371.2, Definitions. Chapter 3 quotes the first sentence of paragraph (a) exactly and summarizes relevant qualifications. Read the entire section for the carrier exception and bona fide agent definition. eCFR displayed Title 49 current through October 26, 2026 at review.
Open original source

S10 · FMCSA, Definitions of Broker and Bona Fide Agents, final guidance, June 16, 2023, Federal Register document 2023-13080. Relevant to dispatch-service activities and status.
Open original source

S11 · FMCSA Registration. Start here for current registration, authority, insurance, and account resources. At review, FMCSA identified Motus as its new USDOT Registration System. This book avoids assuming older account screens remain current.
Open original source

S12 · FBI, Business Email Compromise. Business-message impersonation, independent payment verification, account security, and immediate financial-institution contact after a suspected fraudulent transfer.
Open original source

S13 · Federal Trade Commission, How To Spot, Avoid, and Report Fake Check Scams. Deposited funds becoming available does not establish that a check is valid; overpayment-and-refund requests are a known pattern.
Open original source

S14 · 49 CFR 371.3, Records to be kept by brokers. Chapter 10 quotes paragraph (c) exactly. The section also specifies transaction records and three-year retention. The quotation does not substitute for advice about an individual contract dispute.
Open original source

Reporting and further reading

S15 · FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center. Official complaint entry point and warning about IC3 impersonation and recovery claims. A report does not guarantee an individual response or recovery.
Open original source

S16 · FTC ReportFraud. Official reporting entry point for scams and suspicious business practices.
Open original source

S17 · FMCSA, Eligible Complaints. Describes the current complaint system and directs users to complaint.fmcsa.dot.gov. Use the appropriate category; ordinary commercial disputes and regulatory complaints are not interchangeable.
Open original source

S18 · U.S. Department of Transportation, Office of Inspector General Hotline. Official reporting route for allegations within its remit. The hotline number is also listed in FMCSA's fraud guidance.
Open original source

S19 · FMCSA, Insurance Filing Requirements. Official registration-related insurance information. Filings and a certificate do not settle every policy-coverage question; consult the relevant policy and insurer or qualified insurance professional.
Open original source

Freight University reading connections

Freight Broker Complaint links at the end of chapters point to relevant articles or its filing guide. It is an independent private resource, not a government agency or a substitute for legal advice, insurance notice, or official reporting. The articles are supplemental reading; the official sources above govern the legal and agency statements in this book.

LFS Shield links point to relevant descriptions of its services. At review, its public site described beta work and selective forthcoming access. The links are not a claim that every advertised capability is generally available, independently tested, or guaranteed. Confirm current availability, scope, data handling, and response arrangements directly before relying on a feature. This book does not endorse claims of guaranteed origin tracing, automatic recovery, or certainty about a sender's identity.

The Freight University teaching basis emphasizes verifying people and authority, checking the transaction, controlling information and payment changes, preserving evidence, and returning lessons to the team. The finished book expands those principles into practical procedures. It does not reproduce private operational records or confidential user biography.

About this edition

Dummy's Guide to Not Getting Scammed

Michael Thomas • Freight University Library

First edition • October 2026

Prepared for trucking companies and the people who act for them. The book's purpose is practical learning: ask the next useful question, confirm the answer through an independent route, and leave a record another person can understand.

The next useful step is small. Take the verification form to the next new inquiry. Use it before you send the packet, book the truck, or accept the change.